

Understand & Map the Sources

Study Guide - Extended Response

1. Learning goal

Understand exactly what the ER asks and build a fast map of both arguments before choosing a stronger source.

2. What this skill means

The Extended Response is not a personal-opinion essay. You read two arguments, identify what each source claims, what evidence it uses, how the reasoning works, and what limits the source admits or ignores. A source map gives you the raw material for a fair judgment.

3. Do not confuse it with

Summary tells what a source says. Mapping separates claim, evidence, reasoning, and limitation so you can evaluate the argument. Personal agreement is different again: you may disagree with the better-supported source and still choose it.

4. How GED-style questions may ask it

Prompts may ask which position is better supported, which source uses stronger evidence, or how the authors support their claims.

5. Repeatable method

- Read the prompt and circle the task verb: analyze, evaluate, determine.
- For Source A, note claim → evidence → reasoning → limitation.
- Repeat for Source B.
- Do not choose a winner until both maps are complete.
- Mark any place where a source predicts, assumes, or qualifies something.

6. Worked example

Source A reports a six-month pilot with measured results and admits the sample was small. Source B raises two possible risks but gives no data showing they occurred.

Question: What should the map record?

Reasoning: A map should record Source A's measured evidence and limitation, and Source B's risks plus the missing support. That makes the later comparison evidence-based.

Best answer: Map both sources first; judge second.

7. Common traps

- Choosing the side you personally like.
- Copying facts without identifying what claim they support.
- Ignoring a limitation because it seems to weaken your preferred source.
- Treating a prediction as if it were measured evidence.

8. Diagnostic help

- If your notes are mostly full sentences, shorten them to claim/evidence/reasoning/limit labels.
- If you choose a winner immediately, force yourself to write one strength and one weakness for each source first.
- If your map has no limitations, check for words such as may, could, limited, only, or however.

9. Quick check

A source reports a 12 percent improvement in a pilot but notes that only two sites participated.

What are the evidence and limitation?

Check yourself: Evidence: 12 percent improvement. Limitation: only two sites participated.